

Social Security couple. The elderly have some special expenses you don't share. They spend much of their \$743 a month on medicine, therapy, and special diets. They face huge hospital bills, even with Medicare. They have to take cabs every place they go. They refuse to move to a warmer climate, with lower heating costs, because they're terrified of the unknown. They fall prey to mail-order swindlers, stingy landlords, and quack healers.

Your retired life on \$743 a month will be totally different. You and your spouse or partner are young, vital, and healthy. You'll gladly walk up three flights of stairs to save \$100 or \$200 a month in rent. Medical care will be a once-in-a-while expense rather than a monthly routine. You'll enjoy saving money by shopping for fresh fish, meat, fruit, and vegetables at the farmers' market. You'll need to plan for your white-haired years. You must avoid the life of the wretched Social Security couple in Baltimore. But while you're young, you'll be having so much fun you'll endure life's little hardships without really noticing.

In your \$743-a-month retirement, you can collect 1890s memorabilia, travel through South America, write songs for your jazz band, play tennis, start a foundation to help disadvantaged kids, take photos, study Scandinavian history, take up farming in Idaho, chop wood in Vermont, study philosophy, restore an old Lasalle, or simply sleep a little later each morning. You may feel like reading poetry for the first time since college, and you may even try your hand at writing some. Instead of talking to your friends and family by long-distance telephone, you'll go visit them for a week or two, or write long letters. You'll not only forget about your job, you'll wonder why you put up with it for so long.

Still, \$743 a month puts you below the poverty level for a two-person household in America. Uncle Sam doesn't even make you pay taxes. That's why I believe you should consider bare-bones retirement only if "normal" retirement at age 35 or 40—with \$400,000 or more in the bank—is out of